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By Mathieu Pollet · Oct 26, 2026, 9:33 AM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — The European Union is fighting Elon Musk's Starlink on at least five fronts —from blocking access, to boosting rivals, to drafting new rules aimed directly at undermining the tech mogul's growing dominance over space business.

The world's richest man is expanding his grip on space and looking to turn his satellite broadband champion Starlink into a "major mobile carrier ." The recent news that the system's military-grade service in Ukraine was slowed down , hampering Kyiv's defenses against Russian attacks, exposed — yet again — the risks of relying on one man's business during wartime.

In Europe, governments and companies fear the reliance on Musk's technology — and they're ramping up their efforts to push back.

POLITICO breaks down five ways the European Union is trying to crack down on the dominance of Musk's satellites in our skies.

1. Clearing the path for a Starlink rival

European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen has thrown her weight behind a deal between Airbus, Leonardo and Thales to combine their satellite and space businesses in a single heavyweight, codenamed "Bromo" and a possible rival to SpaceX, Starlink's parent company.

"These are the types of industrial champions we need if Europe is to lead in the space economy of tomorrow," von der Leyen told an international space summit in Paris last month. It's highly unusual for the Commission president to express support for a proposed merger that has yet to be approved by EU competition regulators.

The joint venture aims to replicate part of SpaceX's formula for success by bringing satellite manufacturing, ground systems and space services under one single roof. But the deal is not guaranteed to clear EU antitrust rules and, even if regulators approve it, the venture could take years to match the scale and capabilities of Musk's space businesses.

2. Blocking Musk from the airwaves

The European Commission earlier this year moved to reserve critical parts of satellite frequencies — known as spectrum — to European players to ensure security and keep control over the prized asset. The chunks Europe wants for itself are well suited to provide mobile connectivity directly to a phone without any cell tower or extra dish.

The move immediately sparked pushback from Musk's company: "The proposal creates a significant likelihood that Europeans will be left without direct-to-device satellite service or that new European operations will create global interference problems, including to emergency services like those in Ukraine," SpaceX warned in a four-page plea obtained by POLITICO .

Now, European governments are working to make it easier for European telecom giants to get the coveted airwaves. Ultimately, Starlink would still be able to apply for some of the satellite frequencies but the EU wants to keep a stronger grip over the asset.

3. Building an EU satellite network

The EU has been working to develop its very own satellite constellation — dubbed IRIS² — that would eventually provide governments with secure communications and citizens with reliable broadband.

"The war in Ukraine has shown how much Europe's security depends on space. And there again, Europe must do more and this is an urgent need we're having for ourselves," Commission spokesperson Thomas Regnier told reporters.

But the ambitious plan is already years behind schedule. Services were supposed to start in 2024, with full capacity by 2027. Costs have also climbed, with some of the bill landing on the next EU budget, which is under fierce negotiation. The first of the constellation's 348 satellites are now due to launch in 2029, with initial services planned for 2030 at the earliest — compared with Starlink's more than 10,000 satellites already in orbit.

4. Giving Ukraine an alternative to Starlink

In recent weeks, Ukrainian forces have faced Starlink speed limits that hampered efforts to intercept Russian attack drones and carry out mid-range strikes. On Saturday, Ukraine's defense minister said services had been restored, allowing the country's forces to once again operate drones at high speed — though shortly after Musk said on X that Kyiv was violating Starlink's terms of service by using it for offensive drone attacks.

The saga has increased pressure on the EU executive to let Kyiv tap into an existing secure satellite project run by several EU countries, called Govsatcom . That system went live in early 2026 and is meant to support governments' critical communication services until the IRIS² constellation becomes operational.

Negotiations between Brussels and Kyiv officially started in March 2026 but have yet to lead to any breakthough. The EU's Govsatcom would also not match what Starlink can offer — though it could serve as a fall-back option.

"What I don't understand is why the European Commission and the Member States have not done everything possible to quickly reach an agreement that would allow Ukraine to benefit from it," French member of the European Parliament Christophe Grudler said in an interview .

5. Waging lawfare on Starlink

Legislators in Brussels are currently working on at least three bills and regulatory initiatives that could hamper, slow down or complicate Starlink's expansion in Europe.

The European Parliament's lead negotiator for an overhaul of the bloc's telecom rules, Polish centrist Michał Kobosko, wants Musk to comply with new supply chain security rules when seeking EU authorization for Starlink services, according to his proposal obtained by POLITICO, and with tougher obligations on data retention, how to handle lawful interception and the designation of legal representatives.

Meanwhile, the EU's first-ever space bill, currently under discussion, is set to impose new cybersecurity, space-debris and environmental rules on Starlink and other foreign satellite operators.

These rules may not be enough to stop Starlink, but they prompted the U.S. State Department to blast them as "unacceptable regulatory burdens" that "appear targeted specifically against U.S. companies" in a recent consultation. The head of the U.S. communications regulator Brendan Carr told POLITICO in March that the U.S. will retaliate and impose restrictions on EU services if U.S. players are hampered.

Starlink didn't respond to POLITICO's request for comment.

Francesca Micheletti contributed to this report.

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